

# Steering Reference Card

The one page worth keeping.

DECIDE BY FOUR PROPERTIES

When it loads · Survives compaction · Context cost · Authority

## 1 The seven methods

where does this instruction belong?

| METHOD               | WHEN IT LOADS                                                      | SURVIVES COMPACTION                    | CONTEXT COST                        | USE IT FOR                                                       |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CLAUDE.md (root)     | Session start; re-read after compaction                            | Yes — memoized                         | Always in context (keep <200 lines) | Facts & soft conventions Claude needs all the time               |
| CLAUDE.md (subdir)   | On-demand when working in that dir                                 | Partial                                | Low — loads only when relevant      | Folder-specific facts                                            |
| Rules                | Always (unscoped) or on file-match (path-scoped)                   | Yes                                    | Low-medium                          | Path-scoped conventions (e.g. per-project C# rules)              |
| Skills               | On /name or auto-match by description                              | n/a — invoked                          | Low until triggered                 | A 30-line+ procedure with steps                                  |
| Subagents            | When spawned                                                       | Isolated context; only summary returns | Cheap to parent context             | Out-of-sight heavy work; cost lever via model:                   |
| Hooks                | On events: SessionStart, PreToolUse, PostToolUse, Stop, PreCompact | n/a — deterministic                    | None — runs as code                 | "Every time X, do Y"; real guardrails (PreToolUse exit 2 blocks) |
| Output styles        | Session config                                                     | n/a                                    | None                                | Changing how Claude formats responses                            |
| Append-system-prompt | Session start (flag)                                               | Yes                                    | Adds to every turn                  | One-off system-prompt additions                                  |

## 2 Three decisions you'll actually use

**a** "Every time X, always do Y" → **hook**  
The model choosing to run a formatter ≠ it actually running.

**b** "Never do X" → **NOT a CLAUDE.md line**  
Use hooks · permissions · managed settings (org-wide, non-overridable).

**c** A 30-line procedure → **skill**  
CLAUDE.md is for facts Claude needs all the time.

## 3 "Where does this go?"



Try the most deterministic / cheapest home first.

## 4 .NET copy-paste starters

```
PATH-SCOPED C# RULE — .CLAUDE/RULES/DATA-ACCESS.MD
---
paths: ["BookTracker.Data/**/*.cs"]
---
Use async EF Core calls; never block on .Result.
```

```
SKILL FOLDER LAYOUT
.claude/skills/add-api-endpoint/
├ SKILL.md
├ references/
└ scripts/
```

```
SUBAGENT — .CLAUDE/AGENTS/TEST-WRITER.MD
---
name: test-writer
description: Generates xUnit tests
model: claude-haiku-4-5
---
# body = system prompt
```

```
GUARDRAIL HOOK — SETTINGS.JSON
{ "hooks": { "PreToolUse": [{
  "matcher": "Bash",
  "hooks": [{ "type": "command",
    "command": ".claude/hooks/block-destructive.sh" }]
}] } }
```

## 5 Gotchas worth remembering

- **Skills are folders, not files.** Subagents are `.md`, not `.yaml`.
- Path-scoped rules load **on read, not create** — make creation-time rules unscoped.
- User-level `~/ .claude/rules/` `paths:` is currently unreliable — use project-level.
- A skill's **description** is a trigger written for the model; its **Gotchas** section is the high-value part.